



coastal regions and further immigrants came from the Muslim world. Today, 16 million Malagasy comprise almost 20 distinct ethnic groups, sharing a language, a nationality, and many similar beliefs and customs. The

incredible diversity of Madagascar's human population is matched by the variety of its animals and plants, which evolved in the millions of years after the island broke off from the African mainland.

The importance of fady

Complex and varied *fady*, or taboos, exist in every group on Madagascar. For instance, the Mahafaly people in the south of the island consider it unlucky for children to sleep in the same house as their parents. Some *fady* are concerned with the proper way to treat the dead.

CARING FOR THE DEAD

Around half of the Malagasy people follow traditional religions, but even those who are Christian retain the traditional beliefs and practices concerning the *razana*, or dead ancestors. *Razana* must be kept happy or they will bring bad luck to the living.

Some graves in the south of the island are decorated with carved figures and the horns of zebu cattle.



1 Family reunion

Some years after the death and burial of a relative, the Merina and Betsileo people of the central highlands dig up the body and wrap the bones in a new shroud.



2 A new shroud

The *famadibana*, or "turning of the dead" allows relatives to show respect for a *razana* and ensure that he or she will continue to protect them in the future.



3 Homes for the dead

Not everyone performs the *famadibana*, but all Malagasy take good care of the dead. On Madagascar, tombs are often more lavish than the homes of the living.

VANILLA



Madagascar produces half of the world's vanilla—a complicated crop to produce. Each plant must be pollinated by hand, allowed to grow for six months, and then undergo a series of processes for a further three months.